

ESPIRITO SANTO AND BAHIA BRAZIL

Moqueca on the Brazilian Coast

The coastline of the Espírito Santo and Bahia states is dotted with tiny fishing villages and glorious bays, where turtles nest in warm white sands and whales calf around the coral islands offshore. It was here that Europeans first set foot in Brazil, 500 years ago, and were doubtless offered a form of *moqueca*, a creamy seafood stew that is still the regional dish today.



Like Columbus before him, the Portuguese explorer Pedro Alvares Cabral was on his way to India in search of spices when he stumbled on Brazil on Easter Day in 1500. His coxswain sighted the spectacular verdant peak of Monte Pascoal, shrouded in rain forest and fringed with coral sand beaches. Instead of spices, Cabral found tantalizing tropical fruits and brilliantly colored berries, both of which were used in the rich cooking of the local Tupi-speaking peoples. The first Portuguese person to write about Tupi cooking was Padre Luís de Grã, who commented on the delicious way the locals prepared meat and fish – *carne* and *peixe* – as a *moquecada*, where the meat or fish is wrapped in a leaf or placed in a clay pot with Brazilian herbs, chili peppers, and root vegetables, then cooked over red-hot embers.

The dish was transformed by the Portuguese, who added European fruits and spices to the pot and served the dish with rice and green vegetables. Renamed *moqueca*, it quickly became one of the most popular dishes in the country. But in the 20th century it sparked a bitter rivalry between the two coastline states of Bahia and Espírito Santo, first sighted by Cabral – as both claimed the dish as their own.

The Bahian *moqueca* is certainly the most Brazilian, though it is a blend of Portuguese, Tupi, and African influences – the shrimp are cooked in *dendê* palm oil and creamy coconut (both introduced to Brazil from Africa). The people of Espírito Santo curl their lip; their *moqueca* – known as *moqueca capixaba* – is, they insist, far closer to the original. It is also preferred by cooking connoisseurs. Juicy shrimp or snookfish are marinated in lime juice and then pan-fried in olive oil in a clay pot. The chef then adds tomatoes, cilantro, and the blood-red juice of *urucum* (annatto) berries, before leaving it to simmer for an hour or so. The dish is served piping hot with a sprinkle of fresh parsley.

Regardless of who's right, it's hard to quarrel in such a peaceful region. The tiny, tranquil villages, forested mountains, and wildly beautiful coastline induce feelings of both awe and contentment, surely echoing Cabral's first impressions, 500 years ago.

What Else to Eat

Nowhere has a richer local cuisine than Espírito Santo, where pre-Columbian indigenous methods of cooking in clay pots have been spiced up with European and African influences and ingredients. **Muma de siri** is a spicy shrimp and crab dish simmered in a clay pot over a wood stove and served with rice and *farofa* (roasted or pan-fried manioc flour). **Torta capixaba** is a seafood tart that's crammed with oysterlike *sururus*, soft-shell crabs, shrimp, and salted codfish. Fruits are myriad and many are unknown outside Brazil. Most make wonderful juices, such as **acerola**, a tart tropical cherry; **umbu**, a berry that's pulped to make a milky liquid; piquant **pitanga** (the Brazilian cherry), and juicy **seriguela**.



The Best Places to Eat Moqueca

Restaurante Céu-Mar inexpensive

This brightly painted little restaurant overlooking the lush banks of the Itaúnas River has been a favorite with visiting Brazilians in the know for well over a decade. They come for the delicious seafood, which is as fresh as it gets – the restaurant's chef plucks the choicest catches of the day from local boats every evening. The menu is broad but the highlight is the seafood *moquecas capixabas*, served bubbling with bright red *urucum* berry juice in traditional clay pots. Portions are big enough for two and come with white rice and a green salad.

Av Bento Daher, Itaúnas, Espírito Santo; open 11:30 AM–midnight; +55 27 3762 5081

Also on the Coast

Maresia's (+55 73 3293 2471; inexpensive)

is a modest, family-run restaurant on Avenida Atlântica, overlooking Alcobaça's beautiful beach. This is where the local Bahian people come for a great *moqueca*. The shrimp and snookfish are so fresh they are almost wriggling, and the huge Bahian *moquecas*, cooked in coconut and *dendê* palm oil, come in a simmering earthenware pot. Be sure to wash them down with a glass of tangy *mangaba* juice, made with fruits plucked from the trees that grow along the nearby river.

Also in Brazil

Bahian chef Neide Santos has created a mini-Bahia in Rio at **Yoruba (+55 21 2541 9387; moderate)**, a colorful little restaurant on Rua Arnaldo Quintela, near the Sugar Loaf mountain. The dining room is decorated with brightly colored Bahian ribbons and drapes and the menu consists almost entirely of Bahian dishes, including huge fish or shrimp *moquecas* big enough for two.

Around the World

Made in Brasil (www.made-in-brasil-bar.co.uk; moderate) in Camden, London, aims to re-create the relaxed feeling of a Brazilian beach café with its tables of unfinished driftwood, shuttered windows, and Latin American music. Its Brazilian chefs produce several types of *moqueca*, including the classic Bahian *moqueca de peixe*, as well as other Brazilian dishes such as *feijoada* (see pp320–21) and *bobo de camarão* (tiger shrimp in a creamy cassava and palm oil sauce).

In Cambridge, Massachusetts, the Brazilian-owned and run **Muqueca Restaurant (www.muquecarestaurant.com; moderate)** serves seven types of *moqueca*, including a plantain and tofu version for vegetarians. Dishes come accompanied by a range of uniquely Brazilian super-fruit juices, including açai (see p303), tart Amazonian *cupuaçu*, and acerola, a vitamin-C super-fruit.



Left A view over the Abrolhos Marine National Park, Bahia